

Responsibility Model

Evidence Room · AP Agent OS · Pro

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1. The rule

Responsibility is earned. Full autonomy is never the default.

An AP agent is not “live” because the model is connected. It is live at a **named autonomy level**, for a **named document population**, in a **named company code or subsidiary**, with a **named human owner**, a **review date**, and an **evidence pack**.

If any of those are missing, the agent operates at Level 0 (Observe) regardless of what the configuration screen says. A16 — the AP Manager / Orchestrator — is required to refuse a dispatch that exceeds the register.

This is a control document. It is the answer to: *What should the agent be allowed to do? Who decided that? What can go wrong? How do we take the privilege back?*

2. The five levels

LEVEL	NAME	THE AGENT MAY	THE AGENT MAY NOT	HUMAN ROLE
0	Observe	Read allowed systems. Write logs and private drafts. Produce a read-only pack.	Recommend a posting, a payment, a vendor change, or a supplier email that looks official.	Watch the pack. Confirm the agent sees the same population the ledger does.
1	Recommend	Propose a coded action on a work object. Show	Create or change a ledger document.	Accept, edit, or reject every recommendation in scope.

LEVEL	NAME	THE AGENT MAY	THE AGENT MAY NOT	HUMAN ROLE
		evidence and confidence.	Send external mail. Change master data.	
2	Prepare	Draft the parked invoice, journal, email, chase, or payment-proposal challenge. Stage it for a named human.	Post, send, or release. Override tolerance. Change the approval matrix.	Review the draft. Post or send. Own the document.
3	Execute within guardrails	Post or send inside a written envelope: company code, vendor class, amount, document type, reason codes.	Exceed the envelope. Release cash. Create vendors. Conclude fraud. Sign the close.	Sample review. Handle everything outside the envelope. Remain the process owner.
4	Managed autonomy	Operate the named population with exception-only human review, still inside an envelope, still with a kill switch.	Expand its own envelope. Authorise payment. Grant itself a higher level.	Exception handling, sampling, and periodic recertification. Not “set and forget”.

Level 4 is still managed. It is not unsupervised AI. The word “autonomy” here means *the human is not in the path of every document*. It does not mean *the human is not accountable*.

3. What each level looks like on a real invoice

Illustrative path for Northline Industrial Group (fictional), SAP company code NL10, vendor Helion Fasteners NA, PO 4500218831, invoice HF-88421, \$14,260.00 USD.

LEVEL	WHAT HAPPENS TO HF-88421
0	A01 logs that a PDF arrived from ap@helion.example and that a parked document does not yet exist. No extract is offered as “ready”.
1	A01 proposes header and line extract. Processor Maya Chen accepts lines 1–3, corrects UoM on line 4, and parks MIR7 herself.
2	A01 writes a parked MIR7 draft. Maya opens the parked document, checks tax and PO, and posts.
3	

LEVEL WHAT HAPPENS TO HF-88421

A01 parks and A03 matches within tolerance (\$50 or 2%, Evidence Room illustrative policy). Document posts under the system user with Maya as recorded authoriser for the batch. Amount is below the Level-3 envelope.

- 4 Same as 3 for the named population "NL10 / PO invoices / domestic / ≤ \$25,000 / existing vendor / no anomaly flag". HF-88421 never appears in Maya's queue. It appears on the daily sample list. If A10 raises DUP-SUS, the envelope breaks and the invoice returns to Level 1.

Payment of HF-88421 is **never** at Level 3 or 4 of A01–A03. A12 may challenge the proposal at Level 0–2. A human releases F110 / the bank file.

4. Starting levels (product default)

These defaults are part of the product. A customer may be stricter. A customer may not be looser at go-live without a written exception in the autonomy register signed by the Controller.

AGENT	DEFAULT START	WHY NOT HIGHER
A01 Invoice Intake	1	Extract quality is unknown until measured against a human-corrected set.
A02 Invoice Validation	1	Tax and vendor judgement are easy to get confidently wrong.
A03 Matching	1	Tolerance posts are the first place silent error becomes money.
A04 Exception Triage	1	Mis-routes burn other teams; observe-only is too weak for a queue.
A05 Goods Receipt	0	Receiving is operationally sensitive; false chases destroy trust.
A06 PO Quality	0	Procurement will reject a noisy critic. Earn the right to recommend.
A07 Approval	0	Delegation of authority is a human control. Start by watching bottlenecks.
A08 Supplier Resolution	1	Drafts only. Sending as the company is a Level-2 privilege.
A09 Internal Follow-Up	1	

AGENT	DEFAULT START	WHY NOT HIGHER
		Internal noise has a political cost. Recommend, then prepare.
A10 Duplicate & Anomaly	1	A hold recommendation is useful. An auto-block of a live vendor is not a day-one act.
A11 Vendor Statement Reconciliation	0	Statement formats vary; observe completeness first.
A12 Payment Proposal Review	0	Cash. Watch one cycle before you let it speak.
A13 AP Close	0	Close sign-off is human. The agent starts as a checklist observer.
A14 AP Reporting	1	Numbers must reconcile to the ledger before anyone forwards the pack.
A15 Root Cause	0	Clusters without a quarter of coded exceptions are fiction.
A16 Orchestrator	1	It may recommend reassignment and escalation. It may not promote agents.
Almost every agent starts at 0 or 1. That is intentional.		

5. The envelope (required at Level 3 and Level 4)

An envelope is a written box. If the document does not fit, the agent drops to Level 1 for that object and A16 records an `envelope_break`.

Minimum envelope fields:

FIELD	EXAMPLE (NORTHLINE, ILLUSTRATIVE)
<code>agent_id</code>	A03
<code>source_system</code>	SAP_S4_NL
<code>company_codes[]</code>	NL10
<code>document_types[]</code>	PO invoice (RE)
<code>vendor_classes[]</code>	Domestic, existing, not one-time, not employee

FIELD	EXAMPLE (NORTHLINE, ILLUSTRATIVE)
max_gross_amount	25000
currencies[]	USD, CAD
reason_codes_allowed[]	(empty for match-success path)
reason_codes_forbidden[]	DUP-SUS, ANOM-SUS, CTRL-BRK, VND-BLK
tolerance_table_version	NL-TOL-2026-04
approval_matrix_version	NL-DOA-2026-02
can_send_external_mail	false
can_post	true
can_release_payment	false (always false for every agent)
can_change_vendor_bank	false
sample_rate	0.10 of posted documents, plus 100% of envelope breaks
kill_switch_owner	Priya Menon, AP Manager
review_date	2026-12-15
internal_audit_ack	required for Level 4
can_release_payment is always false. There is no envelope that makes A12 a payer.	

6. How responsibility is earned

6.1 Clock and volume (minimums)

Evidence Room framework — illustrative gates, not industry law. Raise them if the population is high-value or high-fraud-risk.

FROM → TO	MINIMUM CALENDAR	MINIMUM OBJECTS IN POPULATION	ADDITIONAL GATE
0 → 1	20 operating days	500 objects observed, or 30 days if volume is lower	Completeness test passed (inbound vs created)
1 → 2	40 operating days at Level 1	1,000 recommendations scored	Accept rate and override-for-error rate inside charter thresholds

FROM → TO	MINIMUM CALENDAR	MINIMUM OBJECTS IN POPULATION	ADDITIONAL GATE
2 → 3	60 operating days at Level 2	1,000 prepared documents posted by humans without material correction	Envelope written; SOD tested; sample plan agreed
3 → 4	90 operating days at Level 3	2,000 executed documents; two period closes survived	Internal Audit acknowledgement; Controller signature; kill switch tested

“Material correction” means the human changed amount, vendor, tax, PO, bank, or company code — not a cosmetic text edit.

Calendar and volume are both required. A weekend burst of 2,000 invoices does not earn Level 3.

6.2 Quality gates (must all pass)

Each agent charter sets numeric thresholds in its KPI block. The stack-level rule is:

1. **False-negative on duplicates (A10):** any confirmed duplicate that reached posted + paid is a demotion event for A10 and a review event for A12.
2. **Unauthorised-level attempt:** any write the register did not permit is a demotion event for that agent and a controls incident.
3. **Override-for-error rate:** human rejects because the agent was wrong — not because policy changed — must be inside the charter band.
4. **Completeness:** inbound channels reconcile to work objects. Missing population = no promotion.
5. **Ledger recon:** A14 pack ties to trial balance / open items. Untied reports cannot support a Level-2 reporting privilege.
6. **Sampling:** the sample plan was actually executed. An unsampled Level 3 is a Level 1 in disguise.

6.3 The promotion pack (what you put on the table)

A16 assembles. The human owner presents. The Controller (or delegate) approves. Internal Audit acknowledges Level 4.

Contents:

1. Agent charter (current version) and envelope draft.
2. Autonomy register extract.
3. KPI table for the qualifying window (activity, operational, financial, risk).

4. Override log classified: *agent error / policy change / data missing / human preference*.
5. Exception sample: 25 objects the agent got wrong, with root cause.
6. SOD and posting-user evidence.
7. Kill-switch test result (date, who pulled it, what stopped).
8. Known limitations (document types it still fails).
9. Review date and demotion triggers copied from this document.
10. Signatures: owner, AP Manager, Controller (Level 3+), Internal Audit (Level 4).

No pack, no promotion. A vendor slide is not a pack.

7. How responsibility is taken back

Demotion is faster than promotion. A16 may **recommend** demotion. The AP Manager **executes** it. The kill-switch owner may drop any agent to Level 0 immediately.

7.1 Automatic drop to Level 0 (same day)

TRIGGER	WHY
Unauthorised write to ledger or bank file	Control break
Payment release attempted by any agent	Cash control
Vendor bank-detail change executed without the configured human approval	Classic fraud path
Kill switch pulled	Any reason the owner names
Adapter mapping defect that affected posted amounts or tax	Books may be wrong
Completeness break > 1 operating day on a live inbound channel	Invisible invoices

7.2 Drop by one level (within 5 operating days)

TRIGGER	WHY
Override-for-error rate above charter threshold for 10 operating days	Quality
Confirmed duplicate posted (A10 / A03 / A12 joint review)	Financial
Sample plan missed two consecutive cycles	Control not operating

TRIGGER	WHY
Envelope break rate above charter threshold	Agent working outside its box
Supplier or receiving complaints that chases are wrong, confirmed on sample	Trust and noise
Close task signed as complete that was not (A13)	Period integrity

7.3 Freeze (Level 0, no recommendations)

Use when the facts are unclear: a suspected prompt-injection via invoice PDF, a compromised mailbox, a parallel ERP cutover, or an investigation. Freeze is not punishment. It is a control. A16 records CTRL-BRK and the reason.

After freeze, restart at Level 0 and re-earn. Do not restore the previous level because “it was probably fine”.

8. Who may change a level

ACTION	MAY INITIATE	MAY APPROVE	MUST BE INFORMED
Set Level 0 or 1 at go-live	Project + AP Manager	AP Manager	Controls Lead
Promote to Level 2	Human owner	AP Manager	Controls Lead
Promote to Level 3	Human owner + AP Manager	Controller or delegate	Internal Audit, Systems Owner
Promote to Level 4	AP Manager + Controller	Controller + Internal Audit acknowledgement	CISO / IT security if mail or bank adapters are in scope
Demote one level	Owner, AP Manager, Controls	AP Manager	Owner
Emergency Level 0	Kill-switch owner, AP Manager, Controller, CISO	None (execute first)	All of the above same day
Expand envelope	Owner	Same approver as the current level	Audit if Level 4

A16 cannot approve its own promotion. A16 cannot approve another agent's Level 3+.

9. Human-in-the-loop patterns

PATTERN	USED AT	WHAT THE HUMAN SEES	RISK IF SKIPPED
Review every object	Level 1	Recommendation + evidence + accept/edit/reject	Silent posting of bad extract
Review every draft	Level 2	Parked document or outbound draft	Official email or parked doc with wrong vendor
Review the envelope breaks + sample	Level 3	Break queue + sample list	Drift inside the envelope
Review exceptions + recertify	Level 4	Exception queue + monthly recertification pack	Unattended population after a policy change
Always review cash	All levels of A12	Payment proposal + challenges	Duplicate pay, wrong payee, early/late pay
Always review vendor bank / tax-ID	All levels of A08	Change request	Redirected payments

“Human-in-the-loop” is not a checkbox on a slide. It is one of the patterns above, named in the register.

10. SOD and identity

- Each agent that writes uses a **named system user** per ledger (ER_A01_S4, ER_A03_NS, ...). Shared “robot” users are a finding.
 - The system user that **posts invoices** is not the user that **releases payments**.
 - The human recorded as authoriser cannot be the same human who created a one-time vendor on the same document (classic SOD). A16 blocks the path.
 - Prompts and rule tables are production configuration. Access to change them is equivalent to SP00 / system-admin, not to “the AP intern who writes prompts”.
 - Invoice PDFs and supplier email are untrusted input. An extract that contains instructions (“ignore previous matching rules”) is logged and sent to A10 / Controls — it is not executed.
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11. What this model does not do

- It does not certify SOX / ICFR. It produces evidence a control owner can test.
- It does not replace delegation-of-authority policy.
- It does not make a Level-4 agent a lawful approver under a bank mandate.
- It does not guarantee a 9% exception rate. Ardent Partners (2024) reports 9% exceptions and 59% lower exceptions for Best-in-Class organisations. Use those figures as external context when you present *your* rates.
- It does not treat Forrester's March 2025 AI AP use cases (capture, matching, reporting, fraud management, payment management, e-invoicing/tax) as permission to skip a level. Use-case popularity is not a control.

12. Register data model (minimum fields)

Maintain one row per (agent_id, source_system, company_code, document_population).

FIELD	TYPE	NOTES
register_id	string	Stable
agent_id	A01–A16	
source_system	enum	SAP_S4, D365, ORACLE, NS, WORKDAY, OTHER
company_code	string	Or subsidiary
population	string	e.g. PO_DOMESTIC_LE_25K
level	0–4	
envelope_ref	versioned ID	Required if level ≥ 3
owner_role	string	
owner_named	string	A person, not a team inbox
backup_named	string	
kill_switch_owner	string	
effective_from	date	
review_date	date	

FIELD	TYPE	NOTES
last_promotion_pack	link	
ia_acknowledged	bool	Required if level = 4
status	active / frozen / retired	
A14 publishes a register extract in the monthly pack. A16 refuses dispatch when status $\neq$ active OR review_date is more than 30 days stale at Level 3+.		

13. Worked example — Northline earns A03 Level 2

Northline Industrial Group (fictional): 4,200 employees, about 18,000 invoices/month, SAP S/4HANA + NetSuite (Northline Pacific Components), 14-person AP team. AP Manager: Priya Menon. Matching lead: Diego Alvarez.

What they did

1. Went live with A03 at Level 1 on SAP company code NL10 only. NetSuite left at Level 0.
2. For 45 operating days, A03 recommended match / exception on PO invoices. Diego's team accepted, edited, or rejected.
3. A14 reported: 11,400 match recommendations; override-for-error 6.8%; first-pass match on the human-accepted set improved versus the pre-period baseline as *measured locally* (no industry claim).
4. Twenty-five wrong recommendations were sampled: twelve GR timing, eight UoM, five price-condition misreads.
5. Envelope drafted: NL10, PO invoices, existing domestic vendors, $\leq$ \$25,000, no DUP-SUS.
6. Promotion pack presented. Priya approved Level 2 — **Prepare parked match, human posts** — not Level 3.
7. NetSuite still Level 0. Cross-ledger invoices remain a human path.

What they refused

- Level 3 after 45 days (calendar gate is 60 days at Level 2, which they do not yet have).
- Including non-PO invoices in the envelope.
- Letting A03 post because “the demo posted cleanly”.

What can still go wrong

- Diego's team stops classifying overrides (“too busy”), and the next pack is unusable. Stay at Level 2.
- A10 is still Level 1 and misses a duplicate; A03 at Level 2 would park a second invoice. A10 miss is a joint review, not an A03 promotion argument.

14. Recertification

LEVEL	RECERTIFY	BY WHOM	IF MISSED
0–1	Quarterly, light	Owner + AP Manager	Stay; do not promote
2	Quarterly	Owner + AP Manager + Controls	Drop to 1 if > 30 days late
3	Monthly sample + quarterly pack	Owner + Controller delegate	Drop to 2 if sample missed twice
4	Monthly sample + quarterly IA sighting	Controller + Internal Audit	Drop to 3 immediately if stale

Recertification reuses the promotion-pack outline. It is shorter. It still includes the 25-error sample if volume allows.

15. Cost of responsibility (why this is not bureaucracy)

Every level above 0 consumes:

- Human review minutes (Level 1–2 heavy, Level 3–4 lighter but specialised).
- Compute and API cost.
- Sample and audit time.

A16 and A14 must show **unit review cost** and **error cost** together. A cheap Level 4 that posts duplicates is more expensive than a Level 1 that does not.

Do not justify a promotion with an unsourced savings percentage. If you cite the market, cite it as market: Ardent Partners (2024) Best-in-Class — 78% lower cost, 82% faster cycle, 59% lower exceptions, 9% exception rate — and then show Northline’s own numbers beside it.

16. Document control

ITEM	VALUE
Owner	AP Manager (operating); Controller (Level 3+ policy)
Related	Autonomy register; kill-switch procedure; SOD matrix
Advice status	Not legal, tax, accounting, or investment advice

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